

SEB & SIG

The grand patriarch is dead, long live the boys from Montsalvat

Montsalvat, one of Melbourne's genuine architectural follies, was once a bastion for Bohemians. KEITH DUNSTAN revisited it to discover the changes.

WHEN we were kids we knew all about Montsalvat. Libidinous things went on there. Probably they sacrificed children on altars. There was sedition talk, free love, they painted each other in the nude and there were stories that old Jorgy had a private harem.

Montsalvat was at Hillcrest Avenue,

Eltham, and was loaded with dangerous Bohemians. There was an air of amusement. Some called it Disneyland on the Yarra, some called it Jorgensen's Camelot but slowly it picked up prestige and recognition as Melbourne's one genuine architectural folly.

Justus Jorgensen, son of a Norwegian sea captain, considered himself the 20th century Rembrandt. He and his colony of disciples started building Montsalvat in 1935 and it was still being built when he died, aged 82, on May 15, 1975.

What with institutions all around us perishing from lack of money, what with Betty Roland, one of the original disciples, writing a book, *The Eye of the Beholder*, about Justus Jorgensen, it seemed a good idea to visit the modern lair of Montsalvat, Sigmund to discover

Sebastian (left), Sigmund Jorgensen

how it was surviving in the 1980s.

Not any more could you call it Disneyland on the Yarra. It has aged beautifully. It looks like a Benedictine monastery or, at the very least, a 16th-century French manor house. As you drive in you have to be careful not to run over one of the strutting peacocks.

Sigmund Jorgensen, born 1940, is the second son of Justus. He is bearded, beautifully rotund, the amiable antithesis of his father. He looks like that commercial of Keith Michell playing Henry VIII. His office, too, is splendidly Tudor; vast stone floor, fireplace big enough to cook a moose, leadlight windows, ceiling as lofty as a tree.

Sigmund works the clock around; he

divides his life, eight hours to Montsalvat, eight hours to Clichy. Clichy is his very successful restaurant in Peel Street, Collingwood. He called it Clichy after the French red light district made famous by Henry Miller.

"The idea amused me at the time," he said. "I have been accused of prostituting Montsalvat. Besides, it's an easy name to remember. The yuppies call it Cliches and the under-yuppies call it Clickies."

But one was interested to know how Montsalvat was managing to meet its bills. It was doing all right, with a sort of split personality. It was a tourist attraction; people paid to come in and they had wedding receptions at the rate of one a week. You could see it was a wonderful, awesome place where one could get married. But then there was the other side and Sigmund took off. "Montsalvat is very important in my view. It is part of the national estate and we are trying to protect it, make it a trust. It is a place where up-and-coming artists and craftsmen can come and perhaps rent a studio and work among other artists."

"At the moment we have a violin and cello maker, Warren Fordham, very talented. We have Matcham Skipper, the silversmith. Lesley Sinclair, the painter, although 83, continues to teach and work here. David Moore, the painter, came here recently."

And he told of his brother Sebastian, whom he calls Seb. Seb is two years older and lean. Many say that as a guitar player he is on a level with John Williams with whom he trained in London. Sebastian is harder to catch. He has a farm at Christmas Hills and he teaches guitar at Montsalvat from 3 pm.

But when you try to pin down Sigmund on the finances of Montsalvat it is not easy. Turnover \$200,000? \$300,000? He fiddled with his calculator. "Yes, about \$300,000. It's not big."

And he grinned: "That reminds me of a story about Matcham Skipper. He had someone like yourself, getting a piece of jewellery. He had this calculator. He flicked on the switches... 'Yes, yes... Mmm, that'll cost you \$300.' So I said, 'By God, Matcham, you're getting smart with adding machines.' He replied: 'Aw yes, but it doesn't work'."

The image, the feel, even the ghost of Justus Jorgensen hangs over the place. More than 3,000 of his paintings are still stored upstairs, paintings that he refused to show in his lifetime. Jorgensen had three children. Max, the son of his wife Lily, was named in honour of Max Meldrum. Then there was Sebastian, named after Bach, and Sigmund, named after Sigmund Freud, both the children of Helen Skipper. Helen still lives at Montsalvat.

Sigmund is both defensive and loyal

about his father. He always refers to his father as Jorg, pronounced Yurg. He is not happy about Betty Roland's book. He thinks she painted a picture of an intellectual guru who used his mental power to dominate his lesser, mediocre little tribe at Montsalvat. "It wasn't like that," he said. "I think she missed the excitement of the place."

And was it an exciting place in which to grow up?

"I was born here. It was terribly interesting because such a lot of things were happening. Originally we had our own little school. Jorg and people here were very interested in education. It went for three or four years and we did things such as French and modern dancing, unheard of at a conventional State school."

"Then we went off to Research State School, a one-room, two-teacher school. Next we went to Eltham High and we were there in its golden years. Phillip Adams was in the same class as Seb."

Danila Vassilieff the artist was one of the teachers. He was sacked, or if he wasn't sacked he only lasted two terms. Too eccentric. His classes were a riot. His kids did a lot of good work, interesting paintings. He released inhibitions. "He did things the kids loved. One day the headmaster put his nose through the door. Danila picked up a duster, threw it at him and it just hit the glass in front of the head's face. That didn't improve their relationship."

But what of Jorgensen, the grand patriarch? Sigmund always found him stern, austere.

"He wasn't the sort of person who ran up to you, picked you up and gave you a big cuddle. He didn't show much affection. He was a disciplinarian. Not that he ever hit me. He aimed a kick at me once when I let off a jumping jack under the table."

"But he was disciplined. We always had to eat at the same times, dinner at seven, lunch at 12, breakfast at 7.30."

He remembers Max Teichmann and Clif Pugh coming back after the war. There was Mervyn Skipper, who was Melbourne representative of *The Bulletin*. "Clif used to work for Mervyn. He had Mervyn's wife build a mud-brick toilet which promptly fell over. But they all built things together and there was an extraordinary camaraderie in those days."

There were people such as George Chalmers, Arthur Munday and Matcham Skipper and at dinner there were long discussions and arguments.

"At various times friends and other people would come as guests. It was very unwise if they tried to come without an invitation. My father hated people just turning up on the doorstep. There were a million cases when Jorg would see you through the window... 'Don't ask that dreadful person to dinner. Get rid of